

Heuristic Evaluation

Usability Evaluation Materials

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Overview

Heuristic Evaluation (Nielsen and Molich, 1990; Nielsen, 1994) is a method of usability evaluation where an analyst finds usability problems by checking the user interface against a set of supplied heuristics or principles.

A set of evaluation materials for the heuristics described in (Nielsen, 1994) are presented, in particular:

- A structured description of Heuristic Evaluation to ease learning and use;
- A self assessed test to allow analysts to assess their understanding of Heuristic Evaluation;
- A checklist of heuristics for use in the analysis;
- Problem record sheets to record usability problems during analysis. Currently, these only record the usability problem predicted. In future, these could be modified to include recommended solutions to these problems (Jeffries, 1994);
- A questionnaire to fill in after the analysis

Acknowledgements

Heuristic Evaluation was originally proposed by Nielsen and Molich (Nielsen and Molich, 1990). A structure has been applied to the heuristics described in (Nielsen, 1994) and to the best of our intentions we have kept the original meanings of the individual heuristics. The structure and any unintended changes to the meanings remain the responsibility of the authors and not Jakob Nielsen.

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References

Jeffries, R. (1994). "Usability Problem Reports: Helping evaluators communicate effectively with developers", In Nielsen, J. and Mack, R. L. (Eds.), *Usability Inspection Methods*. John Wiley and Sons, New York.

Nielsen, J. (1994). "Heuristic Evaluation", In Nielsen, J. and Mack, R. L. (Eds.), *Usability Inspection Methods*. John Wiley and Sons, New York, pp. 25-62.

Nielsen, J. and Molich, R. (1990). "Heuristic Evaluation of User Interfaces", In *Proceedings of ACM CHI'90 Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, pp. 249-256.

Conditions of Use

We welcome collaborators in our research into analytic evaluation methods. These materials can be used for Research and Development subject to the following conditions:

- You must E-mail Darryn Lavery (darryn@dcs.gla.ac.uk) informing him of the use and purpose of use of these materials.
- You will inform Darryn of any results or experiences from using the materials by filling in the supplied questionnaire.
- All acknowledgements and copyright messages must remain on the materials.
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Heuristic Evaluation

Introduction

Heuristic Evaluation (Nielsen and Molich, 1990; Nielsen, 1994) is a method of usability evaluation where an analyst finds usability problems by checking the user interface against a set of supplied heuristics or principles.

Heuristics

The following heuristics were proposed by Nielsen (Nielsen, 1994). Each heuristic is presented in a structured manner, with one or more of the following elements:

Conformance Question

What the system should do, or users should be able to do, to satisfy the heuristic.

Evidence of Conformance

Things to look for , for example design features or lack of design features that indicate partial satisfaction or breaches of the heuristic.

Motivation

Usability problems that the heuristic tries to avoid.

1. Visibility of System Status

Conformance Question

Are users kept informed about system progress with appropriate feedback within reasonable time?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks.

Motivation

Feedback allows the user to monitor progress towards solution of their task, allows the closure of tasks and reduces user anxiety.

2. Match between system and the real world

Conformance Question

Does the system use concepts and language familiar to the user rather than system-oriented terms. Does the system use real-world conventions and display information in a natural and logical order?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through user studies (or through assumptions about users!), and through the analysis of individual tasks.

Motivation

A good match minimises the extra knowledge required to use the system, simplifying all task action mappings (re-expression of users intuitions into system concepts).

3. User control and freedom

Conformance Question

Can users do what they want when they want?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence takes the form of a diverse set of design features, for example “undo and redo”, clearly marked exits etc.

Motivation

Quite simply, users often choose actions by mistake.

4. Consistency and Standards

Conformance Question

Do design elements such as objects and actions have the same meaning or effect in different situations?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through several analyses (consistency within system, conformance to style guides, consistency across task methods).

Motivation

Consistency minimises user knowledge required to use system by letting users generalise from existing experience of the system or other systems.

5. Error prevention

Conformance Question

Can users make errors which good designs would prevent?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks and of system details (e.g. adjacency of function keys and menu options, discriminability of icons and labels).

Motivation

Errors are the main source of frustration, inefficiency and ineffectiveness during system usage.

6. Recognition rather than recall

Conformance Question

Are design elements such as objects, actions and options visible? Is the user forced to remember information from one part of a system to another.

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks.

Motivation

Forcing users to remember details such as command and file names is a major source of error. Recognition minimises user knowledge required to use the system. Summarising available commands or options may allow the user to guess their meaning or purpose.

7. Flexibility and efficiency of use

Conformance Question

Are task methods efficient and can users customise frequent actions or use short cuts?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks, and the presence of design features such as keyboard accelerators etc.

Motivation

Inefficient task methods can reduce user effectiveness and cause frustration.

8. Aesthetic and minimalist design

Conformance Question

Do dialogues contain irrelevant or rarely needed information?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks.

Motivation

Cluttered displays have the effect of reducing search times for commands or users missing features on the screen. Users unfamiliar with a system often have to find an action to meet a particular need — reducing the number of actions available could make the choice easier.

9. Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors

Conformance Question

Are error messages expressed in plain language (no codes), do they accurately describe the problem and suggest a solution?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of error messages.

Motivation

Errors are the main source of frustration, inefficiency and ineffectiveness during system usage.

10. Help and documentation

Conformance Question

Is appropriate help information supplied, and is this information easy to search and focused on the user's tasks?

Evidence of Conformance

Necessary evidence takes the form of help documentation which should be easy to search, focused on the user's task and present a short list of actions to perform.

Motivation

Ideally, a system should not require documentation. However, it may be necessary to provide help which users need to access at very short notice.

Acknowledgements

Heuristic Evaluation was originally proposed by Nielsen and Molich (Nielsen and Molich, 1990).

This presentation of Heuristic Evaluation has been developed for use on UK EPSRC project no. GR/K82727 (Extending HCI Design Principles and Task Analysis for Software and Data Visualisation) by Darryn Lavery, Gilbert Cockton and Malcolm Atkinson. A structure has been applied to the heuristics described in (Nielsen, 1994), and to the best of our intentions we have kept the original meanings of the individual heuristics. The structure and any unintended changes to the meanings remain the responsibility of the authors and not Jakob Nielsen.

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References

- Nielsen, J. (1994). "Heuristic Evaluation", In Nielsen, J. and Mack, R. L. (Eds.), *Usability Inspection Methods*. John Wiley and Sons, New York, pp. 25-62.
- Nielsen, J. and Molich, R. (1990). "Heuristic Evaluation of User Interfaces", In *Proceedings of ACM CHI'90 Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*, pp. 249-256.

Heuristic Evaluation

Check List

This check list has been supplied as a reading aid to the Heuristic Evaluation method and as a reminder for the evaluation of the prototype

1. *Visibility of System Status*

Are users kept informed about system progress with appropriate feedback within reasonable time?

2. *Match between system and the real world*

Does the system use concepts and language familiar to the user rather than system-oriented terms. Does the system use real-world conventions and display information in a natural and logical order?

3. *User control and freedom*

Can users do what they want when they want?

4. *Consistency and Standards*

Do design elements such as objects and actions have the same meaning or effect in different situations?

5. *Error prevention*

Can users make errors which good designs would prevent?

6. *Recognition rather than recall*

Are design elements such as objects, actions and options visible? Is the user forced to remember information from one part of a system to another.

7. *Flexibility and efficiency of use*

Are task methods efficient and can users customise frequent actions or use short cuts?

8. *Aesthetic and minimalist design*

Do dialogues contain irrelevant or rarely needed information?

9. *Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors*

Are error messages expressed in plain language (no codes), do they accurately describe the problem and suggest a solution?

10. *Help and documentation*

Is appropriate help information supplied, and is this information easy to search and focused on the user's tasks?

Acknowledgements

These heuristics were originally suggested by Jakob Nielsen.

These materials have been developed for use on UK EPSRC project no. GR/K82727 (Extending HCI Design Principles and Task Analysis for Software and Data Visualisation) by Darryn Lavery, Gilbert Cockton and Malcolm Atkinson. A structure has been applied to the heuristics, and to the best of our intentions we have kept the original meanings of the individual heuristics. The structure and any unintended changes to the meanings remain the responsibility of the authors and not Jakob Nielsen.

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Heuristic Evaluation

Self Assessed Test

To test your understanding of Heuristic Evaluation, try this quick self test. The answers can be found in the back of this test.

What is the Conformance Question?

For each of the heuristics in the table below, match the conformance question from the list supplied below. For example if the heuristic “Consistency and Standards” has the conformance question “Can users do what they want when they want?”, then mark “B” in the appropriate part of the table.

Heuristic	Conformance Question
Visibility of System Status	
Match between system and the real world	
User control and freedom	
Consistency and Standards	
Error prevention	
Recognition rather than recall	
Flexibility and efficiency of use	
Aesthetic and minimalist design	
Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors	
Help and documentation	

Match the following conformance questions to the heuristics in the table above.

- (A) Is appropriate help information supplied, and is this information easy to search and focused on the user’s tasks?
- (B) Can users do what they want when they want?
- (C) Are users kept informed about system progress with appropriate feedback within reasonable time?
- (D) Do dialogues contain irrelevant or rarely needed information?
- (E) Are error messages expressed in plain language (no codes), do they accurately describe the problem and suggest a solution?

- (F) Does the system use concepts and language familiar to the user rather than system-oriented terms. Does the system use real-world conventions and display information in a natural and logical order?
- (G) Do design elements such as objects and actions have the same meaning or effect in different situations?
- (H) Are design elements such as objects, actions and options visible? Is the user forced to remember information from one part of a system to another.
- (I) Are task methods efficient and can users customise frequent actions or use short cuts?
- (J) Can users make errors which good designs would prevent?

What is the Evidence of Conformance?

For each of the heuristics in the table below, match the evidence of conformance from the list supplied below. For example, if the heuristic "Consistency and Standards" matches "Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks", then mark "F" in the appropriate part of the table.

Heuristic	Evidence of Conformance
Visibility of System Status	
Match between system and the real world	
User control and freedom	
Consistency and Standards	
Error prevention	
Recognition rather than recall	
Flexibility and efficiency of use	
Aesthetic and minimalist design	
Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors	
Help and documentation	

Match the following evidence of conformance to the heuristics in the table above. Three heuristics will have evidence of conformance "A".

- (A) Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks (3).
- (B) Necessary evidence must be identified through user studies (or through assumptions about users!), and through the analysis of individual tasks.
- (C) Necessary evidence must be identified through several analyses (consistency within system, conformance to style guides, consistency across task methods).
- (D) Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks and of system details (e.g. adjacency of function keys and menu options, discriminability of icons and labels).
- (E) Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of individual tasks, and the presence of design features such as keyboard accelerators etc.
- (F) Necessary evidence must be identified through analysis of error messages.

- (G) Necessary evidence takes the form of help documentation which should be easy to search, focused on the user's task and present a short list of actions to perform.
- (H) Necessary evidence takes the form of a diverse set of design features, for example "undo and redo", clearly marked exits etc.

What is the Motivation?

For each of the heuristics in the table below, match the motivation from the list supplied below. For example if the heuristic “User control and freedom” has the motivation “Feedback allows the user to monitor progress towards solution of their task, allows the closure of tasks and reduces user anxiety”, then mark “E” in the appropriate part of the table.

Heuristic	Motivation
Visibility of System Status	
Match between system and the real world	
User control and freedom	
Consistency and Standards	
Error prevention	
Recognition rather than recall	
Flexibility and efficiency of use	
Aesthetic and minimalist design	
Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors	
Help and documentation	

Match the following motivations to the heuristics in the table above. Two of the heuristics will have motivation “A”.

- (A) Errors are the main source of frustration, inefficiency and ineffectiveness during system usage (2).
- (B) Ideally, a system should not require documentation. However, it may be necessary to provide help which users need to access at very short notice.
- (C) Feedback allows the user to monitor progress towards solution of their task, allows the closure of tasks and reduces user anxiety.
- (D) Cluttered displays have the effect of reducing search times for commands or users missing features on the screen. Users unfamiliar with a system often have to find an action to meet a particular need — reducing the number of actions available could make the choice easier.
- (E) Inefficient task methods can reduce user effectiveness and cause frustration.

- (F) Forcing users to remember details such as command and file names is a major source of error. Recognition minimises user knowledge required to use the system. Summarising available commands or options may allow the user to guess their meaning or purpose.
- (G) A good match minimises the extra knowledge required to use the system, simplifying all task action mappings (re-expression of users intuitions into system concepts).
- (H) Quite simply, users often choose actions by mistake.
- (I) Consistency minimises user knowledge required to use system by letting users generalise from existing experience of the system or other systems.

Answers

What is the Conformance Question?

Heuristic	Conformance Question
Visibility of System Status	C
Match between system and the real world	F
User control and freedom	B
Consistency and Standards	G
Error prevention	J
Recognition rather than recall	H
Flexibility and efficiency of use	I
Aesthetic and minimalist design	D
Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors	E
Help and documentation	A

What is the Evidence?

Heuristic	Evidence of Conformance
Visibility of System Status	A
Match between system and the real world	B
User control and freedom	H
Consistency and Standards	C
Error prevention	D
Recognition rather than recall	A
Flexibility and efficiency of use	E
Aesthetic and minimalist design	A
Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors	F
Help and documentation	G

What is the Motivation?

Heuristic	Motivation
Visibility of System Status	C
Match between system and the real world	G
User control and freedom	H
Consistency and Standards	I
Error prevention	A
Recognition rather than recall	F
Flexibility and efficiency of use	E
Aesthetic and minimalist design	D
Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors	A
Help and documentation	B

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These heuristics were originally suggested by Jakob Nielsen.

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Heuristic Evaluation

Problem Record Sheet

Problem Number

Description of problem and why it is a problem

How did you find the problem?

Which heuristic(s) does this problem breach?

Problem Number

Description of problem and why it is a problem

How did you find the problem?

Which heuristic(s) does this problem breach?

Heuristic Evaluation

Post-evaluation Questionnaire

Thank you for using these evaluation materials. We would like to assess how well they met your needs and how they were used.

Please could you fill in this questionnaire. The answers you give will remain anonymous. However, we may publish the results, or use them for our own research. If for some reason you can not answer some of the questions then leave the answer blank.

When you have filled in the questionnaire, please return it to:

Darryn Lavery

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United Kingdom

E-Mail: darryn@dcs.gla.ac.uk

Thank you!

Name:

Email address:

Organisation:

Role (e.g. usability specialist, software engineer etc.):

What was the purpose of using the Heuristic Evaluation materials?

Was the evaluation performed individually or by a group? If the evaluation was undertaken by a group, who were the other evaluators?

What type of interactive system was under evaluation?

Please describe the activities performed before the evaluation.

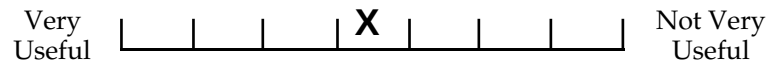
Please describe the evaluation procedure.

Please describe the activities performed after the evaluation.

Please rate the following evaluation materials for usefulness by placing an "X" on the appropriate part of the scale and note any comments you have.

Example

How useful were these materials?

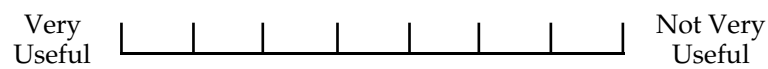


Do you have any comments about these materials?

Use this space for any comments you wish to make about these materials.

Description of Heuristic Evaluation

How useful did you find the description of Heuristic Evaluation?



Do you have any comments about the description?

Heuristic Evaluation Checklist

How useful did you find the checklist of heuristics?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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Do you have any comments about the checklist?

Self Assessed Test

How useful did you find the self assessed test?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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Do you have any comments about the self assessed test?

Problem Record Sheets

How useful did you find the problem record sheets?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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Do you have any comments about the problem record sheets?

Were the evaluation materials supplied sufficient to learn and use Heuristic Evaluation?
Please explain your answer.

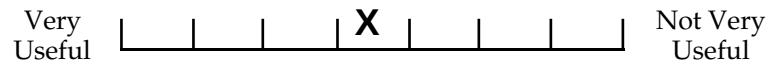
Did you use any other materials, for example research papers, tutorials etc.?

Will you use these materials again? Please explain your answer.

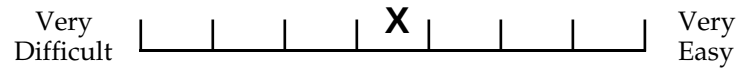
Please rate the following heuristics for importance and ease of use by placing an “X” on the appropriate part of the scale and note any comments you have about the heuristic.

Example

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?



How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

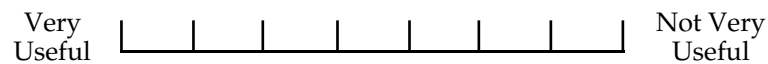


Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

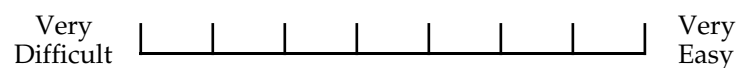
Use this space for any comments you wish to make about this heuristic.

Visibility of System Status

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?



How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?



Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Match between system and the real world

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

User control and freedom

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Consistency and Standards

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Error prevention

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Recognition rather than recall

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Flexibility and efficiency of use

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Aesthetic and minimalist design

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Help users recognize, diagnose and recover from errors

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Help and documentation

How useful was this heuristic for finding usability problems?

Very Useful	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Not Very Useful
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How easy did you find using this heuristic to find usability problems?

Very Difficult	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Very Easy
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Do you have any comments about this heuristic?

Do you have any other comments about Heuristic Evaluation or the materials?

Thanks for your help!